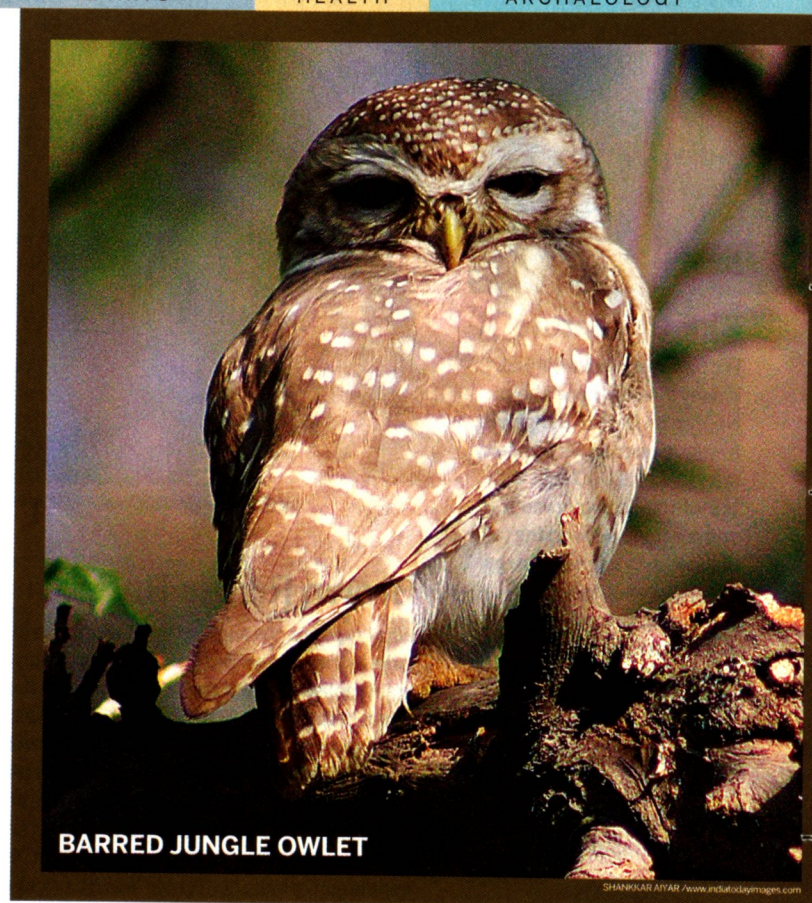


| By M.G. Radhakrishnan |

Foreteller of death and winged messenger of ill-luck, the owl has always had a diabolic aura in the popular imagination. The bird's elusive and nocturnal nature may be to blame, as could be its horns, eerie screech and chilling lidless stare. In Kerala, home to 16 of the 33 owl species found in India, the Mottled Wood Owl is fearfully called "kalan kozhi" (fowl of death) as its midnight call is believed to herald imminent death. Interestingly, while the bird is associated with evil in south India, it is just the opposite in the north. According to Hindu mythology, Goddess Lakshmi, the goddess of wealth, is believed to ride an owl. There's an East-West divide too: in the Western world, owls are considered wise but in most parts of India, they personify foolishness.

Owls have their uses too, albeit some strange ones. Its body parts are prescribed as charms. Traditional healers prescribe concoctions made of owl organs for better night vision, rheumatism and also as an aphrodisiac. Thanks to such superstitions, owl poachers can make Rs 5-10 lakh from a single bird.

The mysteries and superstitions



Avian WARNING

Owls aren't exactly the focus of conservation concerns but new research discovers more species and points to the need for protection to keep them off the endangered list



surrounding the bird are likely to clear up as researchers are learning more about owls and finding more kinds. Scientists of the Kerala Forest Research Institute (KFRI) in Trissur have for the first time in the country developed ecological niche models to demarcate forest owl habitats. During three years of their research, they have recorded as many as 13 species of forest owl in the southern Western Ghats of Kerala and Tamil Nadu. The

study has also found two new species in Kerala's wildlife sanctuaries. They are the Short-eared Owl, a migrant species in Peechi-Vazhani, and the Oriental Bay Owl, an endemic species found in Idukki and Neyyar sanctuaries. Out of the 16 species of owl found in Kerala, nine are found in forests and the rest in open areas. Of these species, two are migrants.

"Information on these nocturnal birds was scanty, except for some